Possibility and certainty

Objective: Express degrees of possibility and certainty about the present, future and past using modals and expressions like *may, might, could, must, can't* and *probably*.

In two lines: Modals show how sure we are about something. For the present we use modal + base verb; for the past we use modal + have + past participle.

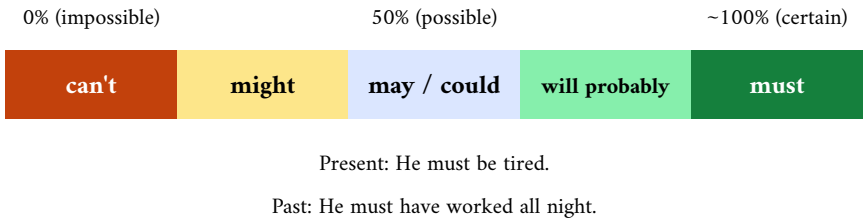


Figure 1: A certainty scale from impossible to almost certain.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **must** = logical certainty that something is true: *The lights are on; they must be at home.*
2. **can't / couldn't** = certainty that something is impossible: *That story can't be true.*
3. **may, might, could** = possibility; *might* is usually less sure: *Aliens might exist.*
4. **Past deduction:** modal + have + past participle: *The UFO may have been a plane.*
5. **Other expressions:** *certainly, definitely, probably, perhaps, it's likely / unlikely that…*
6. **Position:** *probably* comes after *will* but before *won't*: *He will probably come / He probably won't come.*

🟢 Examples

1. Rewrite: I'm sure he forgot his keys. **Answer:** He must have forgotten his keys. **Explanation:** past certainty.
2. Rewrite: It's impossible that she saw a ghost. **Answer:** She can't have seen a ghost.
3. Rewrite: Perhaps scientists will find a cure. **Answer:** Scientists may find a cure. **Explanation:** future possibility.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Using *mustn't* for impossibility; the opposite of deduction *must* is *can't*.
- Writing *must have saw* instead of *must have seen*.
- Adding *to* after modals: *might to be*.
- Using a present modal for a past event: *He must be late yesterday*.

🟡 Quick review

- must = almost certain (yes).
- can't = almost certain (no).
- may / might / could = possible.
- Past: modal + have + V3.
- Rewrite *I'm sure*, *perhaps* and *impossible* with modals.

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